

The story was narrated to Ganesh by a young man, Mahendra by name. He was a junior supervisor in a firm which offered on hire supervisors at various types of construction sites: factories, bridges, dams, and so on. Mahendra's job was to keep an eye on the activities at the work site. He had to keep moving from place to place every now and then as ordered by his head office: from a coal mining area to a railway bridge construction site, from there after a few months to a chemical plant which was coming up somewhere. He was a bachelor. His needs were simple and he was able to adjust himself to all kinds of odd conditions, whether it was an ill-equipped circuit house or a makeshift canvas tent in the middle of a stone quarry. But one asset he had was his cook, Iswaran. The cook was quite attached to Mahendra and followed him uncomplainingly wherever he was posted. He cooked for Mahendra, washed his clothes and chatted away with his master at night. He could weave out endless stories and anecdotes on varied subjects. Iswaran also had an amazing capacity to produce vegetables and cooking ingredients, seemingly out of nowhere, in the middle of a desolate landscape with no shops visible for miles around. He would miraculously conjure up the most delicious dishes made with fresh vegetables within an hour of arriving at the zinc-sheet shelter at the new workplace. Mahendra would be up early in the morning and leave for work after breakfast, carrying some prepared food with him. Meanwhile Iswaran would tidy up the shed, wash the clothes, and have a leisurely bath, pouring several buckets of water over his head, muttering a prayer all the while. It would be lunchtime by then. After eating, he would read for a while before dozing off. The book was usually some popular Tamil thriller running to hundreds of pages. Its imaginative descriptions and narrative flourishes would hold Iswaran in thrall. His own descriptions were greatly influenced by the Tamil authors that he read. When he was narrating even the smallest of incidents, he would try to work in suspense and a surprise ending into the account. For example, instead of saying that he had come across an uprooted tree on the highway, he would say, with eyebrows suitably arched and hands held out in a dramatic gesture, "The road was deserted and I was all alone. Suddenly I spotted something that looked like an enormous bushy beast lying sprawled across the road. I was half inclined to turn and go back. But as I came closer I saw that it was a fallen tree, with its dry branches spread out." Mahendra would stretch himself back in his canvas chair and listen to Iswaran's tales uncritically. "The place I come from is famous for timber," Iswaran would begin. "There is a richly wooded forest all around. The logs are hauled on to the lorries by elephants. They are huge well-fed beasts. When they turn wild even the most experienced mahout is not able to control them." After this prologue Iswaran would launch into an elaborate anecdote involving an elephant. "One day a tusker escaped from the timber yard and began to roam about, stamping on bushes, tearing up wild creepers and breaking branches at will. You know, sir, how an elephant behaves when it goes mad." Iswaran would get so caught up in the excitement of his own story that he would get up from the floor and jump about, stamping his feet in emulation of the mad elephant. "The elephant reached the outskirts of our town; breaking the fences down like matchsticks," he would continue. "It came into the main road and smashed all the stalls selling fruits, mud pots and clothes. People ran helter-skelter in panic! The elephant now entered a school ground where children were playing, breaking through the brick wall. All the boys ran into the classrooms and shut the doors tight. The beast grunted and wandered about, pulling out the football goal-post, tearing down the volleyball net, kicking and flattening the drum kept for water, and uprooting the shrubs. Meanwhile all the teachers had climbed up to the terrace of the school building; from there they

helplessly watched the depredations of the elephant. There was not a soul below on the ground. The streets were empty as if the inhabitants of the entire town had suddenly disappeared. "I was studying in the junior class at that time, and was watching the whole drama from the rooftop. I don't know what came over me suddenly. I grabbed a cane from the hands of one of the teachers and ran down the stairs and into the open. The elephant grunted and menacingly swung a branch of a tree which it held in its trunk. It stamped its feet, kicking up a lot of mud and dust. It looked frightening. But I moved slowly towards it, stick in hand. People were watching the scene hypnotised from nearby housetops. The elephant looked at me red-eyed, ready to rush towards me. It lifted its trunk and trumpeted loudly. At that moment I moved forward and, mustering all my force, whacked its third toenail on the quick. The beast looked stunned for a moment; then it shivered from head to foot — and collapsed." At this point Iswaran would leave the story unfinished, and get up mumbling, "I will be back after lighting the gas and warming up the dinner." Mahendra who had been listening with rapt attention would be left hanging. When he returned, Iswaran would not pick up the thread of the story right away. Mahendra would have to remind him that the conclusion was pending. "Well, a veterinary doctor was summoned to revive the animal," Iswaran would shrug casually. "Two days later it was led away by its mahout to the jungle." "Well, how did you manage to do it, Iswaran — how did you bring down the beast?" "It has something to do with a Japanese art, I think, sir. Karate or ju-jitsu it is called. I had read about it somewhere. It temporarily paralyses the nervous system, you see." Not a day passed without Iswaran recounting some story packed with adventure, horror and suspense. Whether the story was credible or not, Mahendra enjoyed listening to it because of the inimitable way in which it was told. Iswaran seemed to more than make up for the absence of a TV in Mahendra's living quarters. One morning when Mahendra was having breakfast Iswaran asked, "Can I make something special for dinner tonight, sir? After all today is an auspicious day — according to tradition we prepare various delicacies to feed the spirits of our ancestors today, sir." That night Mahendra enjoyed the most delicious dinner and complimented Iswaran on his culinary skills. He seemed very pleased but, unexpectedly, launched into a most garish account involving the supernatural. "You know, sir, this entire factory area we are occupying was once a burial ground," he started. Mahendra was jerked out of the pleasant reverie he had drifted into after the satisfying meal. "I knew on the first day itself when I saw a human skull lying on the path. Even now I come across a number of skulls and bones," Iswaran continued. He went on to narrate how he sometimes saw ghosts at night. "I am not easily frightened by these things, sir. I am a brave fellow. But one horrible ghost of a woman which appears off and on at midnight during the full moon... It is an ugly creature with matted hair and a shrivelled face, like a skeleton holding a foetus in its arms." Mahendra shivered at the description and interrupted rather sharply, "You are crazy, Iswaran. There are no such things as ghosts or spirits. It is all a figment of your imagination. Get your digestive system examined — and maybe your head as well. You are talking nonsense." He left the room and retired for the night, expecting Iswaran to sulk for a couple of days. But the next morning he was surprised to find the cook as cheerful and talkative as ever. From that day on Mahendra, for all his brave talk, went to bed with a certain unease. Every night he peered into the darkness Reprint 2025-26 Iswaran the Storyteller/ 17 outside through the window next to his bed, trying to make sure that there was no movement of dark shapes in the vicinity. But he could only see a sea of darkness with the twinkling lights of the factory miles away. He had always liked to admire the milk-white

landscape on full-moon nights. But after hearing Iswaran's story of the female ghost he avoided looking out of his window altogether when the moon was full. One night, Mahendra was woken up from his sleep by a low moan close to his window. At first he put it down to a cat prowling around for mice. But the sound was too guttural for a cat. He resisted the curiosity to look out lest he should behold a sight which would stop his heart. But the wailing became louder and less feline. He could not resist the temptation any more. Lowering himself to the level of the windowsill he looked out at the white sheet of moonlight outside. There, not too far away, was a dark cloudy form clutching a bundle. Mahendra broke into a cold sweat and fell back on the pillow, panting. As he gradually recovered from the ghastly experience he began to reason with himself, and finally concluded that it must have been some sort of auto suggestion, some trick that his subconscious had played on him. By the time he had got up in the morning, had a bath and come out to have his breakfast, the horror of the previous night had faded from his memory. Iswaran greeted him at the door with his lunch packet and his bag. Just as Mahendra was stepping out Iswaran grinned and said, "Sir, remember the other day when I was telling you about the female ghost with a foetus in its arms, you were so angry with me for imagining things? Well, you saw her yourself last night. I came running hearing the sound of moaning that was coming from your room..." A chill went down Mahendra's spine. He did not wait for Iswaran to complete his sentence. He hurried away to his office and handed in his papers, resolving to leave the haunted place the very next day!

IN the Kingdom of Fools, both the king and the minister were idiots. They didn't want to run things like other kings, so they decided to change night into day and day into night. They ordered that everyone should be awake at night, till their fields and run their businesses only after dark, and go to bed as soon as the sun came up. Anyone who disobeyed would be punished with death. The people did as they were told for fear of death. The king and the minister were delighted at the success of their project. One day a guru and his disciple arrived in the city. It was a beautiful city, it was broad daylight, but there was no one about. Everyone was asleep, not a mouse stirring. Even the cattle had been taught to sleep by day. The two strangers were amazed by what they saw around them and wandered around town till evening, when suddenly the whole town woke up and went about its nightly business. The two men were hungry. Now that the shops were open, they went to buy some groceries. To their astonishment, they found that everything cost the same, a single duddu — whether they bought a measure of rice or a bunch of bananas, it cost a duddu. The guru and his disciple were delighted. They had never heard of anything like this. They could buy all the food they wanted for a rupee. When they had cooked and eaten, the guru realised that this was a kingdom of fools and it wouldn't be a good idea for them to stay there. "This is no place for us. Let's go," he said to his disciple. But the disciple didn't want to leave the place. Everything was cheap here. All he wanted was good, cheap food. The guru said, They are all fools. This won't last very long, and you can't tell what they'll do to you next." But the disciple wouldn't listen to the guru's wisdom. He wanted to stay. The guru finally gave up and said, "Do what you want. I'm going," and left. The disciple stayed on, ate his fill every day — bananas and ghee and rice and wheat, and grew fat like a street-side sacred bull. One bright day, a thief broke into a rich merchant's house. He had made a hole in the wall and sneaked in, and as he was carrying out his loot, the wall of the old house collapsed on his head and killed him on the spot. His brother ran to the king and complained, "Your Highness, when my brother was pursuing his ancient trade, a wall fell on him and killed him. This merchant is to blame. He should have built a good,

strong wall. You must punish the wrongdoer and compensate the family for this injustice.” The king said, “Justice will be done. Don’t worry,” and at once summoned the owner of the house. When the merchant arrived, the king questioned him. “What’s your name?” “Such and Such, Your Highness.” “Were you at home when the dead man burgled your house?” “Yes, My Lord. He broke in and the wall was weak. It fell on him.” “The accused pleads guilty. Your wall killed this man’s brother. You have murdered a man. We have to punish you.” “Lord,” said the helpless merchant, “I didn’t put up the wall. It’s really the fault of the man who built the wall. He didn’t build it right. You should punish him.” “Who is that?” “My Lord, this wall was built in my father’s time. I know the man. He’s an old man now. He lives nearby.” The king sent out messengers to bring in the bricklayer who had built the wall. They brought him, tied hand and foot. “You there, did you build this man’s wall in his father’s time?” “Yes, My Lord, I did.” “What kind of a wall is this that you built? It has fallen on a poor man and killed him. You’ve murdered him. We have to punish you by death.” Before the king could order the execution, the poor bricklayer pleaded, “Please listen to me before you give your orders. It’s true I built this wall and it was no good. But that was because my mind was not on it. I remember very well a dancing girl who was going up and down that street all day with her anklets jingling, and I couldn’t keep my eyes or my mind on the wall I was building. You must get that dancing girl. I know where she lives.” “You’re right. The case deepens. We must look into it. It is not easy to judge such complicated cases. Let’s get that dancer, wherever she is.” The dancing girl, now an old woman, came trembling to the court. “Did you walk up and down that street many years ago, while this poor man was building a wall? Did you see him?” “Yes, My Lord, I remember it very well.” “So you did walk up and down, with your anklets jingling. You were young and you distracted him, so he built a bad wall. It has fallen on a poor burglar and killed him. You’ve killed an innocent man. You’ll have to be punished.” She thought for a minute and said, “My Lord, wait. I know now why I was walking up and down that street. I had given some gold to the goldsmith to make some jewellery for me. He was a lazy scoundrel. He made so many excuses, said he would give it now and he would give it then and so on all day. He made me walk up and down to his house a dozen times. That was when this bricklayer saw me. It’s not my fault, My Lord, it’s the damned goldsmith’s fault.” “Poor thing, she’s absolutely right,” thought the king, weighing the evidence. “We’ve got the real culprit at last. Get the goldsmith, wherever he is hiding. At once!” The king’s bailiffs searched for the goldsmith, who was hiding in a corner of his shop. When he heard the accusation against him, he had his own story to tell. “My Lord,” he said, “I’m a poor goldsmith. It’s true I made this dancer come many times to my door. I gave her excuses because I couldn’t finish making her jewellery before I finished the rich merchant’s orders. They had a wedding coming, and they wouldn’t wait. You know how impatient rich men are!” “Who is this rich merchant who kept you from finishing this poor woman’s jewellery, made her walk up and down, which distracted this bricklayer, which made a mess of his wall, which has now fallen on an innocent man and killed him? Can you name him?” The goldsmith named the merchant, and he was none other than the original owner of the house whose wall had fallen. Now justice had come full circle, thought the king, back to the merchant. When he was rudely summoned back to the court, he arrived crying, “It wasn’t me but my father who ordered the jewellery! He’s dead! I’m innocent!” But the king consulted his minister and ruled decisively: “It’s true your father is the true murderer. He’s dead, but somebody must be punished in his place. You’ve inherited everything from that criminal father of yours, his riches as well as his sins. I knew at once, even when I first set eyes on you,

that you were at the root of this horrible crime. You must die.” And he ordered a new stake to be made ready for the execution. As the servants sharpened the stake and got it ready for the final impaling of the criminal, it occurred to the minister that the rich merchant was somehow too thin to be properly executed on the stake. He appealed to the king’s common sense. The king too worried about it. “What shall we do?” he said, when suddenly it struck him that all they needed to do was to find a man fat enough to fit the stake. The servants were immediately sent all over the town looking for a man who would fit the stake, and their eyes fell on the disciple who had fattened himself for months on bananas and rice and wheat and ghee. “What have I done wrong? I’m innocent. I’m a sanyasi!” he cried. “That may be true. But it’s the royal decree that we should find a man fat enough to fit the stake,” they said, and carried him to the place of execution. He remembered his wise guru’s words: “This is a city of fools. You don’t know what they will do next.” While he was waiting for death, he prayed to his guru in his heart, asking him to hear his cry wherever he was. The guru saw everything in a vision; he had magic powers, he could see far, and he could see the future as he could see the present and the past. He arrived at once to save his disciple, who had got himself into such a scrape through love of food. As soon as he arrived, he scolded the disciple and told him something in a whisper. Then he went to the king and addressed him, “O wisest of kings, who is greater? The guru or the disciple?” “Of course, the guru. No doubt about it. Why do you ask?” “Then put me to the stake first. Put my disciple to death after me.” When the disciple heard this, he understood and began to clamour, “Me first! You brought me here first! Put me to death first, not him!” The guru and the disciple now got into a fight about who should go first. The king was puzzled by this behaviour. He asked the guru, “Why do you want to die? We chose him because we needed a fat man for the stake.” “You shouldn’t ask me such questions. Put me to death first,” replied the guru. “Why? There’s some mystery here. As a wise man you must make me understand.” “Will you promise to put me to death if I tell you?” asked the guru. The king gave him his solemn word. The guru took him aside, out of the servants’ earshot, and whispered to him, “Do you know why we want to die right now, the two of us? We’ve been all over the world but we’ve never found a city like this or a king like you. That stake is the stake of the god of justice. It’s new, it has never had a criminal on it. Whoever dies on it first will be reborn as the king of this country. And whoever goes next will be the future minister of this country. We’re sick of our ascetic life. It would be nice to enjoy ourselves as king and minister for a while. Now keep your word, My Lord, and put us to death. Me first, remember?” The king was now thrown into deep thought. He didn’t want to lose the kingdom to someone else in the next round of life. He needed time. So he ordered the execution postponed to the next day and talked in secret with his minister. “It’s not right for us to give over the kingdom to others in the next life. Let’s go on the stake ourselves and we’ll be reborn as king and minister again. Holy men do not tell lies,” he said, and the minister agreed. So he told the executioners, “We’ll send the criminals tonight. When the first man comes to you, put him to death first. Then do the same to the second man. Those are my orders. Don’t make any mistake.” That night, the king and his minister went secretly to the prison, released the guru and the disciple, disguised themselves as the two, and as arranged beforehand with loyal servants, were taken to the stake and promptly executed. When the bodies were taken down to be thrown to crows and vultures the people panicked. They saw before them the dead bodies of the king and the minister. The city was in confusion. All night they mourned and discussed the future of the kingdom. Some people suddenly thought of the guru and the disciple and caught up with

them as they were preparing to leave town unnoticed. "We people need a king and a minister," said someone. Others agreed. They begged the guru and the disciple to be their king and their minister. It didn't take many arguments to persuade the disciple, but it took longer to persuade the guru. They finally agreed to rule the kingdom of the foolish king and the silly minister, on the condition that they could change all the old laws. From then on, night would again be night and day would again be day, and you could get nothing for a duddu. It became like any other place HIGH above the city, on a tall column, stood the statue of the Happy Prince. He was gilded all over with thin leaves of fine gold, for eyes he had two bright sapphires, and a large red ruby glowed on his sword hilt. One night there flew over the city a little swallow. His friends had gone away to Egypt six weeks before, but he had stayed behind; then he decided to go to Egypt too. All day long he flew, and at night time he arrived at the city. "Where shall I put up?" he said. "I hope the town has made preparations." Then he saw the statue on the tall column. "I will put up there," he cried. "It is a fine position with plenty of fresh air." So he alighted just between the feet of the Happy Prince. "I have a golden bed-room," he said softly to himself as he looked round, and he prepared to go to sleep; but just as he was putting his head under his wing a large drop of water fell on him. "What a curious thing!" he cried. "There is not a single cloud in the sky, the stars are quite clear and bright, and yet it is raining." Then another drop fell. "What is the use of a statue if it cannot keep the rain off?" he said. "I must look for a good chimney pot," and he determined to fly away. But before he had opened his wings, a third drop fell, and he looked up, and saw — Ah! What did he see? The eyes of the Happy Prince were filled with tears, and tears were running down his golden cheeks. His face was so beautiful in the moonlight that the little swallow was filled with pity. "Who are you?" he said. "I am the Happy Prince." "Why are you weeping then?" asked the swallow. "You have quite drenched me." "When I was alive and had a human heart," answered the statue, "I did not know what tears were, for I lived in the Palace, where sorrow is not allowed to enter. My courtiers called me the Happy Prince, and happy indeed I was. So I lived, and so I died. And now that I am dead they have set me up here so high that I can see the ugliness and all the misery of my city, and though my heart is made of lead yet I cannot choose but weep." "What! Is he not solid gold?" said the swallow to himself. He was too polite to make any personal remarks. "Far away," continued the statue in a low musical voice, "far away in a little street there is a poor house. One of the windows is open, and through it I can see a woman seated at a table. Her face is thin and worn, and she has coarse, red hands, all pricked by the needle, for she is a seamstress. She is embroidering flowers on a satin gown for the loveliest of the Queen's maids of honour, to wear at the next Court ball. In a bed in the corner of the room her little boy is lying ill. He has a fever, and is asking his mother to give him oranges. His mother has nothing to give him but river water, so he is crying. Swallow, Swallow, little Swallow, will you not bring her the ruby out of my sword hilt? My feet are fastened to this pedestal and I cannot move." "I am waited for in Egypt," said the swallow. "My friends are flying up and down the Nile, and talking to the large lotus flowers. Soon they will go to sleep." The Prince asked the swallow to stay with him for one night and be his messenger. "The boy is so thirsty, and the mother so sad," he said. "I don't think I like boys," answered the swallow. "I want to go to Egypt." But the Happy Prince looked so sad that the little swallow was sorry. "It is very cold here," he said. But he agreed to stay with him for one night and be his messenger. "Thank you, little Swallow," said the Prince. The swallow picked out the great ruby from the Prince's sword, and flew away with it in his beak over the roofs of the town. He passed by the

cathedral tower, where the white marble angels were sculptured. He passed by the palace and heard the sound of dancing. A beautiful girl came out on the balcony with her lover. "I hope my dress will be ready in time for the State ball," she said. "I have ordered flowers to be embroidered on it, but the seamstresses are so lazy." He passed over the river, and saw the lanterns hanging on the masts of the ships. At last he came to the poor woman's house and looked in. The boy was tossing feverishly on his bed, and the mother had fallen asleep, she was so tired. In he hopped, and laid the great ruby on the table beside the woman's thimble. Then he flew gently round the bed, fanning the boy's forehead with his wings. "How cool I feel!" said the boy, "I must be getting better;" and he sank into a delicious slumber. Then the swallow flew back to the Happy Prince, and told him what he had done. "It is curious," he remarked, "but I feel quite warm now, although it is so cold." "That is because you have done a good action," said the Prince. And the little swallow began to think, and then fell asleep. Thinking always made him sleepy. When day broke he flew down to the river and had a bath. "Tonight I go to Egypt," said the swallow, and he was in high spirits at the prospect. He visited all the monuments and sat a long time on top of the church steeple. When the moon rose he flew back to the Happy Prince. "Have you any commissions for Egypt?" he cried. "I am just starting." "Swallow, Swallow, little Swallow," said the Prince, "will you stay with me one night longer?" "I am waited for in Egypt," answered the swallow. "Swallow, Swallow, little Swallow," said the Prince, "far away across the city I see a young man in a garret. He is leaning over a desk covered with papers, and in the glass by his side there is a bunch of withered violets. His hair is brown and crisp, and his lips are red as a pomegranate, and he has large and dreamy eyes. He is trying to finish a play for the Director of the Theatre, but he is too cold to write any more. There is no fire in the grate, and hunger has made him faint." "I will wait with you one night longer," said the swallow, who really had a good heart. He asked if he should take another ruby to the young playwright. "Alas! I have no ruby now," said the Prince. "My eyes are all that I have left. They are made of rare sapphires, which were brought out of India a thousand years ago." He ordered the swallow to pluck out one of them and take it to the playwright. "He will sell it to the jeweller, and buy firewood, and finish his play," he said. "Dear Prince," said the swallow, "I cannot do that," and he began to weep. "Swallow, Swallow, little Swallow," said the Prince, "do as I command you." So the swallow plucked out the Prince's eye, and flew away to the young man's garret. It was easy enough to get in, as there was a hole in the roof. Through this he darted, and came into the room. The young man had his head buried in his hands, so he did not hear the flutter of the bird's wings, and when he looked up he found the beautiful sapphire lying on the withered violets. "I am beginning to be appreciated," he cried. "This is from some great admirer. Now I can finish my play," and he looked quite happy. The next day the swallow flew down to the harbour. He sat on the mast of a large vessel and watched the sailors working. "I am going to Egypt," cried the swallow, but nobody minded, and when the moon rose he flew back to the Happy Prince. "I have come to bid you goodbye," he cried. "Swallow, Swallow, little Swallow," said the Prince, "will you not stay with me one night longer?" "It is winter," answered the swallow, "and the snow will soon be here. In Egypt the sun is warm on the green palm trees, and the crocodiles lie in the mud and look lazily about them." "In the square below," said the Happy Prince, "there stands a little matchgirl. She has let her matches fall in the gutter, and they are all spoiled. Her father will beat her if she does not bring home some money, and she is crying. She has no shoes or stockings, and her little head is bare. Pluck out my other eye, and give it to her, and her father

will not beat her." "I will stay with you one night longer," said the swallow, "but I cannot pluck out your eye. You would be quite blind then." "Swallow, Swallow, little Swallow," said the Prince, "do as I command you." So he plucked out the Prince's other eye, and darted down with it. He swooped past the matchgirl, and slipped the jewel into the palm of her hand. "What a lovely bit of glass!" cried the little girl; and she ran home, laughing. Then the swallow came back to the Prince. "You are blind now," he said, "so I will stay with you always." "No, little Swallow," said the poor Prince, "you must go away to Egypt." "No, I will stay with you always," said the swallow, and he slept at the Prince's feet. All the next day he sat on the Prince's shoulder, and told him stories of what he had seen in strange lands. "Dear little Swallow," said the Prince, "you tell me of marvellous things, but more marvellous than anything is the suffering of men and women. There is no Mystery so great as Misery. Fly over my city, little Swallow, and tell me what you see there." So the swallow flew over the great city, and saw the rich making merry in their beautiful houses, while the beggars were sitting at the gates. He flew into dark lanes, and saw the white faces of starving children looking out listlessly at the black streets. Under the archway of a bridge two little boys were lying in each other's arms to try and keep themselves warm. "How hungry we are!" they said. "You must not lie here," shouted the watchman, and they wandered out into the rain. Then he flew back and told the Prince what he had seen. "I am covered with fine gold," said the Prince. "You must take it off, leaf by leaf, and give it to the poor; the living always think that gold can make them happy." Leaf after leaf of the fine gold the swallow picked off, till the Happy Prince looked quite dull and grey. Leaf after leaf of the fine gold he brought to the poor, and the children's faces grew rosier, and they laughed and played in the street. "We have bread now!" they cried. Then the snow came, and after the snow came the frost. The streets looked as if they were made of silver. Everybody went about in furs, and the little boys wore scarlet caps and skated on the ice. The poor little swallow grew colder and colder, but he would not leave the Prince, he loved him too well. He picked up crumbs outside the baker's door when the baker was not looking, and tried to keep himself warm by flapping his wings. But at last he knew that he was going to die. He had just enough strength to fly up to the Prince's shoulder once more. "Goodbye, dear Prince!" he murmured. "Will you let me kiss your hand? "I am glad that you are going to Egypt at last, little Swallow," said the Prince. "You have stayed too long here but you must kiss me on the lips, for I love you." "It is not to Egypt that I am going," said the swallow. "I am going to the House of Death. Death is the brother of Sleep, is he not?" And he kissed the Happy Prince on the lips, and fell down dead at his feet. At that moment a curious crack sounded inside the statue, as if something had broken. The fact is that the leaden heart had snapped right in two. It certainly was a dreadfully hard frost. Early the next morning the Mayor was walking in the square below in company with the Town Councillors. As they passed the column he looked up at the statue. "Dear me! How shabby the Happy Prince looks!" he said. "How shabby, indeed!" cried the Town Councillors, who always agreed with the Mayor and they went up to look at it. "The ruby has fallen out of his sword, his eyes are gone, and he is golden no longer," said the Mayor. "In fact, he is little better than a beggar!" "Little better than a beggar," said the Town Councillors. "And here is actually a dead bird at his feet!" continued the Mayor. "We must really issue a proclamation that birds are not to be allowed to die here." And the Town Clerk made a note of the suggestion. So they pulled down the statue of the Happy Prince. "As he is no longer beautiful he is no longer useful," said the Art Professor at the University. Then they melted the statue in a furnace. "What a strange thing!" said the overseer of

the workmen at the foundry. "This broken lead heart will not melt in the furnace. We must throw it away." So they threw it on a dust heap where the dead swallow was also lying. "Bring me the two most precious things in the city," said God to one of His Angels; and the Angel brought Him the leaden heart and the dead bird. "You have rightly chosen," said God, "for in my garden of Paradise this little bird shall sing for ever more and in my city of gold the Happy Prince shall praise me." SUE and Johnsy, two young artists, shared a small flat. The flat was on the third storey of an old house. Johnsy fell very seriously ill in November. She had pneumonia. She would lie in her bed without moving, just gazing out of the window. Sue, her friend, became very worried. She sent for the doctor. Although he came every day there was no change in Johnsy's condition. One day the doctor took Sue aside and asked her, "Is anything worrying Johnsy?" "No," replied Sue. "But why do you ask?" The doctor said "Johnsy, it seems, has made up her mind that she is not going to get well. If she doesn't want to live, medicines will not help her." Sue tried her best to make Johnsy take an interest in things around her. She talked about clothes and fashions, but Johnsy did not respond. Johnsy continued to lie still on her bed. Sue brought her drawing-board into Johnsy's room and started painting. To take Johnsy's mind off her illness, she whistled while working. Suddenly Sue heard Johnsy whisper something. She quickly rushed to the bed and heard Johnsy counting backwards. She was looking out of the window and was saying, "Twelve!" After sometime she whispered "eleven", then "ten", then "nine", "eight", "seven". Sue anxiously looked out of the window. She saw an old ivy creeper climbing half-way up the brick wall opposite their window. In the strong wind outside, the creeper was shedding its leaves. "What is it, dear?" Sue asked. "Six," whispered Johnsy. "They are falling faster now. Three days ago there were almost a hundred leaves. There are only five left now." "It is autumn," said Sue, "and the leaves will fall." "When the last leaf falls, I will die," said Johnsy with finality. "I have known this for the last three days." "Oh, that's nonsense," replied Sue. "What have old ivy leaves to do with your getting well? The doctor is confident that you will get better." Johnsy did not say anything. Sue went and brought her a bowl of soup. "I don't want any soup," said Johnsy. "I am not hungry... Now there are only four leaves left. I want to see the last one fall before it gets dark. Then I will sleep forever." Sue sat on Johnsy's bed, kissed her and said, "You are not going to die. I can't draw the curtain for I need the light. I want to finish the painting and get some money for us. Please, my dear friend," she begged Johnsy, "promise not to look out of the window while I paint." "All right," said Johnsy. "Finish your painting soon for I want to see the last leaf fall. I'm tired of waiting. I have to die, so let me go away peacefully like one of those poor, tired leaves." "Try to sleep," said Sue. "I have to paint an old miner. I will call Behrman up to be my model." Sue rushed down. Behrman lived on the ground floor. He was a sixty-year-old painter. His lifelong dream was to paint a masterpiece but that had remained a dream. Sue poured out her worries to Behrman. She told him how Johnsy was convinced that she would die when the last leaf fell. "Is she stupid?" asked Behrman. "How can she be so foolish?" "She is running a high temperature," complained Sue. "She refuses to eat or drink and that worries me a lot." "I will come with you and see Johnsy," Behrman said. They tiptoed into the room. Johnsy was sleeping. Sue drew the curtains together and they went to the next room. She peeped out through the window. There was only one leaf on the creeper. It was raining heavily and an icy-cold wind was blowing. It seemed as though the leaf would fall any minute now. Behrman did not say a word. He went back to his room. Johnsy woke up next morning. In a feeble voice she asked Sue to draw the curtains. Sue was nervous. She drew back the

curtains very reluctantly. "Oh!" Sue exclaimed as she looked at the vine creeper. "Look, there is still one leaf on the creeper. It looks quite green and healthy. In spite of the storm and the fierce winds, it didn't fall." "I heard the wind last night," said Johnsy. "I thought it would have fallen. It will surely fall today. Then I'll die." "You won't die," said Sue energetically. "You have to live for your friends. What would happen to me if you die?" Johnsy smiled weakly and closed her eyes. After every hour or so she would look out of the window and find the leaf still there. It seemed to be clinging to the creeper. In the evening, there was another storm but the leaf did not fall. Johnsy lay for a long time looking at the leaf. Then she called out to Sue. "I have been a bad girl. You have looked after me so lovingly and I have not cooperated with you. I have been depressed and gloomy. The last leaf has shown me how wicked I have been. I have realised that it is a sin to want to die." Sue hugged Johnsy. Then she gave her lots of hot soup and a mirror. Johnsy combed her hair and smiled brightly. In the afternoon the doctor came. After examining his patient he told Sue, "Johnsy now has the will to live. I am confident she'll recover soon. Now I must go downstairs and see Behrman. He is also suffering from pneumonia. But I am afraid, there is no hope for him." The next morning Sue came and sat on Johnsy's bed. Taking Johnsy's hand in hers she said, "I have something to tell you. Mr Behrman died of pneumonia this morning. He was ill for only two days. The first day the janitor found him on his bed. His clothes and shoes were wet and he was shivering. He had been out in that stormy night." Then they found a ladder and a lantern still lighted lying near his bed. There were also some brushes and green and yellow paints on the floor near the ladder. "Johnsy dear," said Sue, "look out of the window. Look at that ivy leaf. Haven't you wondered why it doesn't flutter when the wind blows? That's Behrman's masterpiece. He painted it the night the last leaf fell." 'Do you still know me?' I asked. The woman looked at me searchingly. She had opened the door a chink. I came closer and stood on the step. 'No, I don't know you.' 'I'm Mrs S's daughter.' She held her hand on the door as though she wanted to prevent it opening any further. Her face gave absolutely no sign of recognition. She kept staring at me in silence. Perhaps I was mistaken, I thought, perhaps it isn't her. I had seen her only once, fleetingly, and that was years ago. It was most probable that I had rung the wrong bell. The woman let go of the door and stepped to the side. She was wearing my mother's green knitted cardigan. The wooden buttons were rather pale from washing. She saw that I was looking at the cardigan and half hid herself again behind the door. But I knew now that I was right. 'Well, you knew my mother?' I asked. 'Have you come back?' said the woman. 'I thought that no one had come back.' 'Only me.' A door opened and closed in the passage behind her. A musty smell emerged. 'I regret I cannot do anything for you.' 'I've come here specially on the train. I wanted to talk to you for a moment.' 'It is not convenient for me now,' said the woman. 'I can't see you. Another time.' She nodded and cautiously closed the door as though no one inside the house should be disturbed. I stood where I was on the step. The curtain in front of the bay window moved. Someone stared at me and would then have asked what I wanted. 'Oh, nothing,' the woman would have said. 'It was nothing.' I looked at the name-plate again. Dorling it said, in black letters on white enamel. And on the jamb, a bit higher, the number. Number 46. As I walked slowly back to the station I thought about my mother, who had given me the address years ago. It had been in the first half of the War. I was home for a few days and it struck me immediately that something or other about the rooms had changed. I missed various things. My mother was surprised I should have noticed so quickly. Then she told me about Mrs Dorling. I had never heard of her but apparently

she was an old acquaintance of my mother, whom she hadn't seen for years. She had suddenly turned up and renewed their contact. Since then she had come regularly. 'Every time she leaves here she takes something home with her,' said my mother. 'She took all the table silver in one go. And then the antique plates that hung there. She had trouble lugging those large vases, and I'm worried she got a crick in her back from the crockery.' My mother shook her head pityingly. 'I would never have dared ask her. She suggested it to me herself. She even insisted. She wanted to save all my nice things. If we have to leave here we shall lose everything, she says.' 'Have you agreed with her that she should keep everything?' I asked. 'As if that's necessary,' my mother cried. 'It would simply be an insult to talk like that. And think about the risk she's running, each time she goes out of our door with a full suitcase or bag.' My mother seemed to notice that I was not entirely convinced. She looked at me reprovingly and after that we spoke no more about it. Meanwhile I had arrived at the station without having paid much attention to things on the way. I was walking in familiar places again for the first time since the War, but I did not want to go further than was necessary. I didn't want to upset myself with the sight of streets and houses full of memories from a precious time. In the train back I saw Mrs Dorling in front of me again as I had the first time I met her. It was the morning after the day my mother had told me about her. I had got up late and, coming downstairs, I saw my mother about to see someone out. A woman with a broad back. 'There is my daughter,' said my mother. She beckoned to me. The woman nodded and picked up the suitcase under the coat-rack. She wore a brown coat and a shapeless hat. 'Does she live far away?' I asked, seeing the difficulty she had going out of the house with the heavy case. 'In Marconi Street,' said my mother. 'Number 46. Remember that.' I had remembered it. But I had waited a long time to go there. Initially after the Liberation I was absolutely not interested in all that stored stuff, and naturally I was also rather afraid of it. Afraid of being confronted with things that had belonged to a connection that no longer existed; which were hidden away in cupboards and boxes and waiting in vain until they were put back in their place again; which had endured all those years because they were 'things.' But gradually everything became more normal again. Bread was getting to be a lighter colour, there was a bed you could sleep in unthreatened, a room with a view you were more used to glancing at each day. And one day I noticed I was curious about all the possessions that must still be at that address. I wanted to see them, touch, remember. After my first visit in vain to Mrs Dorling's house I decided to try a second time. Now a girl of about fifteen opened the door to me. I asked her if her mother was at home. 'No' she said, 'my mother's doing an errand.' 'No matter,' I said, 'I'll wait for her.' I followed the girl along the passage. An old-fashioned iron Hanukkah¹ candle-holder hung next to a mirror. We never used it because it was much more cumbersome than a single candlestick. 'Won't you sit down?' asked the girl. She held open the door of the livingroom and I went inside past her. I stopped, horrified. I was in a room I knew and did not know. I found myself in the midst of things I did want to see again but which oppressed me in the strange atmosphere. Or because of the tasteless way everything was arranged, because of the ugly furniture or the muggy smell that hung there, I don't know; but I scarcely dared to look around me. The girl moved a chair. I sat down and stared at the woollen table-cloth. I rubbed it. My fingers grew warm from rubbing. I followed the lines of the pattern. Somewhere on the edge there should be a burn mark that had never been repaired. 'My mother'll be back soon,' said the girl. 'I've already made tea for her. Will you have a cup?' 'Thank you.' I looked up. The girl put cups ready on the tea-table. She had a broad back. Just like her mother. She poured tea from a

white pot. All it had was a gold border on the lid, I remembered. She opened a box and took some spoons out. 'That's a nice box.' I heard my own voice. It was a strange voice. As though each sound was different in this room. 'Oh, you know about them?' She had turned round and brought me my tea. She laughed. 'My mother says it is antique. We've got lots more.' She pointed round the room. 'See for yourself.' I had no need to follow her hand. I knew which things she meant. I just looked at the still life over the tea-table. As a child I had always fancied the apple on the pewter plate. 'We use it for everything,' she said. 'Once we even ate off the plates hanging there on the wall. I wanted to so much. But it wasn't anything special.' I had found the burn mark on the table-cloth. The girl looked questioningly at me. 'Yes,' I said, 'you get so used to touching all these lovely things in the house, you hardly look at them any more. You only notice when something is missing, because it has to be repaired or because you have lent it, for example.' Again I heard the unnatural sound of my voice and I went on: 'I remember my mother once asked me if I would help her polish the silver. It was a very long time ago and I was probably bored that day or perhaps I had to stay at home because I was ill, as she had never asked me before. I asked her which silver she meant and she replied, surprised, that it was the spoons, forks and knives, of course. And that was the strange thing, I didn't know the cutlery we ate off every day was silver.' The girl laughed again. 'I bet you don't know it is either.' I looked intently at her. 'What we eat with?' she asked. 'Well, do you know?' She hesitated. She walked to the sideboard and wanted to open a drawer. 'I'll look. It's in here.' I jumped up. 'I was forgetting the time. I must catch my train.' She had her hand on the drawer. 'Don't you want to wait for my mother?' 'No, I must go.' I walked to the door. The girl pulled the drawer open. 'I can find my own way.' As I walked down the passage I heard the jingling of spoons and forks. At the corner of the road I looked up at the name-plate. Marconi Street, it said. I had been at Number 46. The address was correct. But now I didn't want to remember it any more. I wouldn't go back there because the objects that are linked in your memory with the familiar life of former times instantly lose their value when, severed from them, you see them again in strange surroundings. And what should I have done with them in a small rented room where the shreds of black-out paper still hung along the windows and no more than a handful of cutlery fitted in the narrow table drawer? I resolved to forget the address. Of all the things I had to forget, that would be the easiest. Though it was nearly midnight when Andrew reached Bryngower, he found Joe Morgan waiting for him, walking up and down with short steps between the closed surgery and the entrance to the house. At the sight of him the burly driller's face expressed relief. 'Eh, Doctor, I'm glad to see you. I been back and forward here this last hour. The missus wants ye — before time, too.' Andrew, abruptly recalled from the contemplation of his own affairs, told Morgan to wait. He went into the house for his bag, then together they set out for Number 12 Blaina Terrace. The night air was cool and deep with quiet mystery. Usually so perceptive, Andrew now felt dull and listless. He had no premonition that this night call would prove unusual, still less that it would influence his whole future in Blaenelly. The two men walked in silence until they reached the door of Number 12, then Joe drew up short. 'I'll not come in,' he said, and his voice showed signs of strain. 'But, man, I know ye'll do well for us.' Inside, a narrow stair led up to a small bedroom, clean but poorly furnished, and lit only by an oil lamp. Here Mrs Morgan's mother, a tall, grey-haired woman of nearly seventy, and the stout, elderly midwife waited beside the patient, watching Andrew's expression as he moved about the room. 'Let me make you a cup of tea, Doctor, bach,' said the former quickly, after a few moments. Andrew smiled faintly.

He saw that the old woman, wise in experience, realised there must be a period of waiting that, she was afraid he would leave the case, saying he would return later. "Don't fret, mother, I'll not run away." Down in the kitchen he drank the tea which she gave him. Overwrought as he was, he knew he could not snatch even an hour's sleep if he went home. He knew, too, that the case here would demand all his attention. A queer lethargy of spirit came upon him. He decided to remain until everything was over. An hour later he went upstairs again, noted the progress made, came down once more, sat by the kitchen fire. It was still, except for the rustle of a cinder in the grate and the slow tick-tock of the wall clock. No, there was another sound—the beat of Morgan's footsteps as he paced in the street outside. The old woman opposite him sat in her black dress, quite motionless, her eyes strangely alive and wise, probing, never leaving his face. His thoughts were heavy, muddled. The episode he had witnessed at Cardiff station still obsessed him morbidly. He thought of Bramwell, foolishly devoted to a woman who deceived him sordidly, of Edward Page, bound to the shrewish Blodwen, of Denny, living unhappily, apart from his wife. His reason told him that all these marriages were dismal failures. It was a conclusion which, in his present state, made him wince. He wished to consider marriage as an idyllic state; yes, he could not otherwise consider it with the image of Christine before him. Her eyes, shining towards him, admitted no other conclusion. It was the conflict between his level, doubting mind and his overflowing heart which left him resentful and confused. He let his chin sink upon his chest, stretched out his legs, stared broodingly into the fire. He remained like this so long, and his thoughts were so filled with Christine, that he started when the old woman opposite suddenly addressed him. Her meditation had pursued a different course. "Susan said not to give her the chloroform if it would harm the baby. She's awful set upon this child, Doctor, bach." Her old eyes warmed at a sudden thought. She added in a low tone: "Ay, we all are, I fancy." He collected himself with an effort. "It won't do any harm, the anaesthetic," he said kindly. "They'll be all right." Here the nurse's voice was heard calling from the top landing. Andrew glanced at the clock, which now showed half-past three. He rose and went up to the bedroom. He perceived that he might now begin his work. An hour elapsed. It was a long, harsh struggle. Then, as the first streaks of dawn strayed past the broken edges of the blind, the child was born, lifeless. As he gazed at the still form a shiver of horror passed over Andrew. After all that he had promised! His face, heated with his own exertions, chilled suddenly. He hesitated, torn between his desire to attempt to resuscitate the child, and his obligation towards the mother, who was herself in a desperate state. The dilemma was so urgent he did not solve it consciously. Blindly, instinctively, he gave the child to the nurse and turned his attention to Susan Morgan who now lay collapsed, almost pulseless, and not yet out of the ether, upon her side. His haste was desperate, a frantic race against her ebbing strength. It took him only an instant to smash a glass ampule and inject the medicine. Then he flung down the hypodermic syringe and worked unsparingly to restore the flaccid woman. After a few minutes of feverish effort, her heart strengthened; he saw that he might safely leave her. He swung round, in his shirt sleeves, his hair sticking to his damp brow. "Where's the child?" The midwife made a frightened gesture. She had placed it beneath the bed. In a flash Andrew knelt down. Fishing amongst the sodden newspapers below the bed, he pulled out the child. A boy, perfectly formed. The limp, warm body was white and soft as tallow¹. The cord, hastily slashed, lay like a broken stem. The skin was of a lovely texture, smooth and tender. The head lolled on the thin neck. The limbs seemed boneless. Still kneeling, Andrew stared at the child with a haggard frown. The whiteness meant

only one thing: asphyxia, pallida², and his mind, unnaturally tense, raced back to a case he once had seen in the Samaritan, to the treatment that had been used. Instantly he was on his feet. "Get me hot water and cold water," he threw out to the nurse. "And basins too. Quick! Quick!" "But, Doctor—" she faltered, her eyes on the pallid body of the child. "Quick!" he shouted. Snatching a blanket, he laid the child upon it and began the special method of respiration. The basins arrived, the ewer, the big iron kettle. Frantically he splashed cold water into one basin; into the other he mixed water as hot as his hand could bear. Then, like some crazy juggler, he hurried the child between the two, now plunging it into the icy, now into the steaming bath. Fifteen minutes passed. Sweat was now running into Andrew's eyes, blinding him. One of his sleeves hung down, dripping. His breath came pantingly. But no breath came from the lax body of the child. A desperate sense of defeat pressed on him, a raging hopelessness. He felt the midwife watching him in stark consternation, while there, pressed back against the wall where she had all the time remained — her hand pressed to her throat, uttering no sound, her eyes burning upon him—was the old woman. He remembered her longing for a grandchild, as great as had been her daughter's longing for this child. All dashed away now; futile, beyond remedy... The floor was now a dragged mess. Stumbling over a sopping towel, Andrew almost dropped the child, which was now wet and slippery in his hands, like a strange, white fish. "For mercy's sake, Doctor," whimpered the midwife. "It's stillborn." Andrew did not heed her. Beaten, despairing, having laboured in vain for half an hour, he still persisted in one last effort, rubbing the child with a rough towel, crushing and releasing the little chest with both his hands, trying to get breath into that limp body. And then, as by a miracle, the pigmy chest, which his hands enclosed, gave a short, convulsive heave, another... and another... Andrew turned giddy. The sense of life, springing beneath his fingers after all that unavailing striving, was so exquisite it almost made him faint. He redoubled his efforts feverishly. The child was gasping now, deeper and deeper. A bubble of mucus came from one tiny nostril, a joyful iridescent bubble. The limbs were no longer boneless. The head no longer lay back spinelessly. The blanched skin was slowly turning pink. Then, exquisitely, came the child's cry. "Dear Father in heaven," the nurse sobbed hysterically. "It's come — it's come alive." Andrew handed her the child. He felt weak and dazed. About him the room lay in a shuddering litter: blankets, towels, basins, soiled instruments, the hypodermic syringe impaled by its point in the linoleum, the ewer knocked over, the kettle on its side in a puddle of water. Upon the huddled bed the mother still dreamed her way quietly through the anaesthetic. The old woman still stood against the wall. But her hands were together, her lips moved without sound. She was praying. Mechanically Andrew wrung out his sleeve, pulled on his jacket. "I'll fetch my bag later, nurse." He went downstairs, through the kitchen into the scullery³. His lips were dry. At the scullery he took a long drink of water. He reached for his hat and coat. Outside he found Joe standing on the pavement with a tense, expectant face. "All right, Joe," he said thickly. "Both all right." It was quite light. Nearly five o'clock. A few miners were already in the streets: the first of the night shift moving out. As Andrew walked with them, spent and slow, his footfalls echoing with the others under the morning sky, he kept thinking blindly, oblivious to all other work he had done in Blaenelly, "I've done something; oh, God! I've done something real at last." . PATRICK never did homework. "Too boring," he said. He played hockey and basketball and Nintendo instead. His teachers told him, "Patrick! Do your homework or you won't learn a thing." And it's true, sometimes he did feel like an ignoramus. But what could he do? He hated homework. 2. Then

one day he found his cat playing with a little doll and he grabbed it away. To his surprise it wasn't a doll at all, but a man of the tiniest size. He had a little wool shirt with old-fashioned britches and a high tall hat much like a witch's. He yelled, "Save me! Don't give me back to that cat. I'll grant you a wish, I promise you that." 3. Patrick couldn't believe how lucky he was! Here was the answer to all of his problems. So he said, "Only if you do all my homework till the end of the semester, that's 35 days. If you do a good enough job, I could even get A's." 4. The little man's face wrinkled like a dishcloth thrown in the hamper. He kicked his legs and doubled his fists and he grimaced and scowled and pursed his lips, "Oh, am I cursed! But I'll do it.. 6. And true to his word, that little elf began to do Patrick's homework. Except there was one glitch. The elf didn't always know what to do and he needed help. "Help me! Help me!" he'd say. And Patrick would have to help—in whatever way. "I don't know this word," the elf squeaked while reading Patrick's homework. "Get me a dictionary. No, what's even better, look up the word and sound it out by each letter." When it came to maths, Patrick was out of luck. "What are times tables?" the elf shrieked. "We elves never need thaAnd addition and subtraction and division and fractions? Here, sit down beside me, you simply must guide me." Elves know nothing of human history, to them it's a mystery. So the little elf, already a shouter, just got louder. "Go to the library, I need books. More and more books. And you can help me read them too." As a matter of fact, every day in every way that little elf was a nag! Patrick was working harder than ever and was it a drag! He was staying up nights, had never felt so weary, was going to school with his eyes puffed and bleary. Finally, the last day of school arrived and the elf was free to go. As for homework, there was no more, so he quietly and slyly slipped out the back door. nag: one who troubles someone all the time by complaining or asking them to do something drag (an informal word): something dull and uninteresting slyly: secretly Patrick got his A's; his classmates were amazed; his teachers smiled and were full of praise. And his parents? They wondered what had happened to Patrick. He was now the model kid. Cleaned his room, did his chores, was cheerful, never rude, like he had developed a whole new attitude. You see, in the end, Patrick still thought he'd made that tiny man do all his homework. But I'll share a secret, just between you and me. It wasn't the elf; Patrick had done it himself!1. I HAD heard a great deal about Miss Beam's school, but not till last week did the chance come to visit it. 2. When I arrived there was no one in sight but a girl of about twelve. Her eyes were covered with a bandage and shewas being led carefully between the flower-beds by a little boy, who was about four years younger. She stopped, and it looked like she asked him who had come. He seemed to be describing me to her. Then they passed on. 3. 4. 5. Miss Beam was all that I had expected—middle-aged, full of authority, yet kindly and understanding. Her hair was beginning to turn grey, and she had the kind of plump figure that is likely to be comforting to a homesick child. I asked her some questions about her teaching methods, which I had heard were simple. 57 kindly: friendly "No more than is needed to help them to learn how to do things—simple spelling, adding, subtracting, multiplying and writing. The rest is done by reading to them and by interesting talks, during which they have to sit still and keep their hands quiet. There are practically no other lessons." 6. plump: stout, pleasantly fat "The real aim of this school is not so much to teach thought as to teach thoughtfulness—kindness to others, and being responsible citizens. Look out of the window a minute, will you?" I went to the window which overlooked a large garden and a playground at the back. "What do you see?" Miss Beam asked.. 8. 9. HONEYSUCKLE "I see some very beautiful grounds," I said, "and a lot of jolly children. It pains

me, though, to see that they are not all so healthy and active-looking. When I came in, I saw one poor little girl being led about. She has some trouble with her eyes. Now I can see two more with the same difficulty. And there's a girl with a crutch watching the others at play. She seems to be a hopeless cripple." Miss Beam laughed. "Oh, no!" she said. "She's not really lame. This is only her lame day. The others are not blind either. It is only their blind day." I must have looked very surprised, for she laughed again. at play: playing hopeless: unfortunate; without hope lame day: day on which she acts as if she was lame "This is a very important part of our system. To make our children appreciate and understand misfortune, we make them share in misfortune too. Each term every child has one blind day, one lame day, one deaf day, one injured day and one dumb day. During the blind day their eyes are bandaged absolutely and they are on their honour not to peep. The bandage is put on overnight so they wake blind. This means that they need help with everything. Other children are given the duty of helping them and leading them about. They all learn so much this way —both the blind and the helpers.. 8. 9. HONEYSUCKLE

"I see some very beautiful grounds," I said, "and a lot of jolly children. It pains me, though, to see that they are not all so healthy and active-looking. When I came in, I saw one poor little girl being led about. She has some trouble with her eyes. Now I can see two more with the same difficulty. And there's a girl with a crutch watching the others at play. She seems to be a hopeless cripple." Miss Beam laughed. "Oh, no!" she said. "She's not really lame. This is only her lame day. The others are not blind either. It is only their blind day." I must have looked very surprised, for she laughed again. at play: playing hopeless: unfortunate; without hope lame day: day on which she acts as if she was lame "This is a very important part of our system. To make our children appreciate and understand misfortune, we make them share in misfortune too. Each term every child has one blind day, one lame day, one deaf day, one injured day and one dumb day. During the blind day their eyes are bandaged absolutely and they are on their honour not to peep. The bandage is put on overnight so they wake blind. This means that they need help with everything. Other children are given the duty of helping them and leading them about. They all learn so much this way —both the blind and the helpers.0 15. 16. HONEYSUCKLE

"Oh, yes", she said. "Let's go for a little walk. Only you must tell me about things. I shall be so glad when today is over. The other bad days can't be half as bad as this. Having a leg tied up and hopping about on a crutch is almost fun, I guess. Having an arm tied up is a bit more troublesome, because you can't eat without help, and things like that. I don't think I'll mind being deaf for a day—at least not much. But being blind is so frightening. My head aches all the time just from worrying that I'll get hurt. Where are we now?" "In the playground," I said. "We're walking towards the house. Miss Beam is walking up and down the garden with a tall girl." "What is the girl wearing?" my little friend asked. "A blue cotton skirt and a pink blouse." "I think it's Millie?" she said. "What colour is her hair?" "Very light," I said. "Yes, that's Millie. She's the Head Girl." "There's an old man tying up roses," I said. "Yes, that's Peter. He's the gardener. He's hundreds of years old!" 61 "And here comes a girl with curly red hair. She's on crutches." "That's Anita," she said.17. WORKING WITH THE TEXT HONEYSUCKLE And so we walked on. Gradually I discovered that I was ten times more thoughtful than I ever thought I could be. I also realised that if I had to describe people and things to someone else, it made them more interesting to me. When I finally had to leave, I told Miss Beam that I was very sorry to go. "Ah!" she replied, "then there is something in my system after all."1. EVERY year on the occasion of Eid, there was a fair in our village. Eid was celebrated only one day but the fair lasted many

days. Tradesmen from far and wide came there with all kinds of goods to sell. You could buy anything from a small pin to a big buffalo. Uncle took me to the fair. Bhaiya, who worked for us at home, came with us. There was a big crowd at the fair. Uncle was leading us through the crowd when he met a few of his friends. They wanted him to spend some time with them. Uncle asked me whether I would like to look around the fair with Bhaiya till he came back. I was happy to do that. Uncle warned me neither to buy anything nor to go too far out while he was away. I promised that I would wait for him. Bhaiya and I went from shop to shop. There were many things I would have liked to buy, but I waited for Uncle to return. Then we came to what was called the Lucky Shop. The shopkeeper was neither young nor old. He was a middle-aged man. He seemed neither too smart nor too lazy. He wanted everybody to try their luck. There were discs on the table with numbers from one to ten facing down. All you had to do was to pay 50 paise, pick up any six discs, add up the numbers on the discs and find the total. The article marked with that number was yours. 5. An old man paid 50 paise and selected six discs. He added up the numbers on them and found the total was 15. He was given the article marked 15, which was a beautiful clock. But the old man did not want a clock. The shopkeeper obliged him by buying it back for 15 rupees. The old man went away very pleased. 6. 7. Then a boy, a little older than I, tried his luck. He got a comb worth 25 paise. The shopkeeper looked neither happy nor sad. He bought the comb from the boy for 25 paise. The boy tried his luck again. He now got a fountain-pen worth three rupees. Then he tried a third time and got a wrist watch worth 25 rupees. When he tried again he got a table lamp worth more than 10 rupees. The boy was happy and went away with a smile and a good deal of cash. 10. I wanted to try my luck too. I looked at Bhaiya. He encouraged me. I paid 50 paise and took six discs. My luck was not too good. I got two pencils. The shopkeeper bought them from me for 25 paise. I tried again. This time I got a bottle of ink, also of little value. The shopkeeper bought that too for 25 paise. I took a chance for the third time. Still luck was not with me. 8. I had hopes of winning a big prize and continued to try my luck again and again, paying 50 paise each time. But every time I got a trifle. At last I was left with only 25 paise. Again the shopkeeper showed his kindness. He said I could either play once more with 25 paise or settle the account then and there. I played again and the last 25 paise also disappeared. 9. People were looking at me. Some were laughing at my bad luck, but none showed any sympathy. Bhaiya and I went to the place where Uncle had left us and waited for him to return. Presently he came. He looked at me and said, "Rasheed, you look upset. What is the matter?" 10. I did not say anything. Bhaiya told him what had happened. Uncle was neither angry nor sad. He smiled and patted me. He took me to a shop and bought me a beautiful umbrella, biscuits and sweets and some other little gifts. Then we returned home. 11. Back home, Uncle told me that the Lucky Shop man had made a fool of me. "No, Uncle," I said, "it was just my bad luck." "No, my boy," said Uncle, "it was neither good luck nor bad luck." "But, Uncle," I said, "I saw an old man getting a clock and a boy getting two or three costly things." "You don't know, child," Uncle said, "they were all friends of the shopkeeper. They were playing tricks to tempt you to try your luck. They wanted your money and they got it. Now forget about it, and don't tell anybody of your bad luck or your foolishness. 1. JUMMAN Shaikh and Algu Chowdhry were good friends. So strong was their bond of friendship that when either of them went away from the village, the other looked after his family. Both were greatly respected in the village. 2. Jumman had an old aunt who had some property. This she transferred to him on the understanding that she would stay with him and he would look after her. The

arrangement worked well for a couple of years. Then the situation changed. Jumman and his family were tired of the old relative. Jumman became as indifferent to her as his wife, who grudged even the little food that the old lady wanted every day. She swallowed these insults along with her food for a few months. But patience has its limits.. 85 4. One day she spoke to Jumman, "My son, it is now obvious that I am not wanted in your house. Kindly give me a monthly allowance so that I can set up a separate kitchen." "My wife knows best how to run the house. Be patient," said Jumman shamelessly. This made his aunt very angry and she decided to take her case to the village panchayat. For many days, the old lady was seen talking to the villagers explaining her case and seeking their support. Some sympathised with her, others laughed at her and a few others advised her to make it up with her nephew and his wife. At last she came to Algu Chowdhry and spoke to him. "You know, Chachi, Jumman is my best friend. How can I go against him?" Algu said. "But is it right, my son, to keep mum and not say what you consider just and fair?" pleaded the old lady. "Come to the panchayat and speak the truth," she said. Algu didn't reply, but her words kept ringing in his ears. The panchayat was held the same evening under an old banyan tree. Jumman stood up and said, "The voice of the Panch is the voice of God. Let my. The panchayat was held the same evening under an old banyan tree. Jumman stood up and said, "The voice of the Panch is the voice of God. Let myDays passed and, as ill luck would have it, Algu Chowdhry found himself in a tight spot. One of his fine pair of bullocks died, and he sold the other to Samjhu Sahu, a cart driver of the village. The understanding was that Sahu would pay the price of the bullock in a month's time. It so happened that the bullock died within a month. 10. HONEYSUCKLE aunt a monthly allowance, or else the property goes back to her." Now, the two friends were seldom seen together. The bond of friendship between them was broken. In fact, Jumman was Algu's enemy and wanted his revenge. Part III seldom: rarely 11. tight spot: difficult situation Several months after the bullock's death, Algu reminded Sahu of the money he hadn't yet paid. Sahu got very annoyed. "I can't pay you a penny for the wretched beast you sold me. He brought us nothing but ruin. I have a bullock. Use it for a month and then return it to me. No money for the dead bullock," he said angrily. Algu decided to refer the case to the panchayat. For a second time in a few months, preparations for holding the panchayat were made, and both the parties started meeting people seeking their support.FAIR PLAY 12. The panchayat was held under the old banyan tree. Algu stood up and said, "The voice of the Panch is the voice of God. Let Sahu nominate the head Panch. I will abide by his decision." 13. Sahu saw his chance and proposed the name of Jumman. Algu's heart sank and he turned pale. But what could he do? 14. The moment Jumman became head Panch, he realised his responsibility as judge and the dignity of his office. Could he, seated in that high place, have his revenge now? He thought and thought. No, he must notFAIR PLAY 12. The panchayat was held under the old banyan tree. Algu stood up and said, "The voice of the Panch is the voice of God. Let Sahu nominate the head Panch. I will abide by his decision." 13. Sahu saw his chance and proposed the name of Jumman. Algu's heart sank and he turned pale. But what could he do? 14. The moment Jumman became head Panch, he realised his responsibility as judge and the dignity of his office. Could he, seated in that high place, have his revenge now? He thought and thought. No, he must not1. DOGS were once their own masters and lived the way wolves do, in freedom, until a dog was born who was ill pleased with this way of life. He was sick and tired of wandering about by himself8 2. 3. 4. HONEYSUCKLE looking for food and being frightened of those who were stronger than he. He

thought it over and decided that the best thing for him to do was to become the servant of one who was stronger than anyone on earth, and he set out to find such a master. He walked and he walked and he met a kinsman of his, a big wolf who was as strong as he was fierce. "Where are you going, Dog?" the Wolf asked. "I am looking for someone to take up service with. Would you like to be my master, Wolf?" "I don't see why not!" the Wolf said, and this agreed upon, the two of them went on together. kinsman: (old-fashioned word) They walked and they walked, and all of a sudden the Wolf lifted his nose, sniffed, darted quickly off the path and into the bushes and crept deeper into the forest. The Dog was much surprised. 5. "What's come over you, master?" he asked. "What has frightened you so?" "Can't you see? There's a Bear out there, and he might eat up both of us—you and me." Seeing that the Bear was stronger than the Wolf, the Dog decided to take up service with him, and he left the Wolf and asked the Bear to be his master. The Bear agreed to this readily and said, "Let us go and find a herd of cows. I'll kill a cow and then we can both eat our fill." 6. 7. They walked on and soon saw a herd of cows, but just as they were about to come up to it they were stopped by a terrible noise. The cows were mooing loudly and running in a panic in all directions. The Bear looked out from behind a tree, and then he too ran hastily deeper into the forest.²⁰ 8. 9. HONEYSUCKLE "Now, why did I have to come here!" said he to the Dog. "It is the Lion who rules the forest in these parts." "The Lion? Who's he?" "Don't you know? He is the strongest beast on earth!" "Well, then, I'll say goodbye to you, Bear. I want a master who is stronger than anyone on earth!" And off the Dog went to ask the Lion to be his master. The Lion agreed to it, and the Dog stayed with him and served him for a long, long time. It was a good life, and he had nothing to complain of, for there was no stronger beast in the forest than the Lion, and no one dared touch the Dog or offend him in any way. But one day the two of them were walking side by side along a path that ran amid bare cliffs when all of a sudden the Lion stopped. He gave a great roar and struck the ground angrily with his paw with such force that a hole formed there. Then he began to back away very quietly. dared: to be brave enough to do something cliff: a steep, high rock (often at the edge of the sea) "What is it, Master, is anything wrong?" asked the Dog, surprised. "I smell a man coming this way," the Lion said. "We'd better run for it or we'll be in trouble." "Oh, well, then I'll say goodbye to you, Lion. I want a master who is stronger than anyone on earth!. And off the Dog went to join the man and he stayed with him and served him faithfully. This happened long, long ago, but to this day the dog is man's most loyal servant and knows no other master. A YOUNG woodcutter named Taro lived with his mother and father on a lonely hillside. All day long he chopped wood in the forest. Though he worked very hard, he earned very little money. This³⁰ 2. 3. 4. HONEYSUCKLE made him sad, for he was a thoughtful son and wanted to give his old parents everything they needed. One evening, when Taro and his parents were sitting in a corner of their hut, a strong wind began to blow. It whistled through the cracks of the hut and everyone felt very cold. Suddenly Taro's father said, "I wish I had a cup of saké; it would warm me and do my old heart good." This made Taro sadder than ever, for the heart-warming drink called saké was very expensive. 'How do I earn more money?' he asked himself. 'How do I get a little saké for my poor old father?' He decided to work harder than before. whistled through: passed through with a whistling sound 5. cracks: narrow gaps/openings saké : a popular Japanese drink ('sa' is pronounced like 'fa' in 'father' and 'ke' rhymes with 'way') expensive: costly Next morning, Taro jumped out of bed earlier than usual and made his way to the forest. He chopped and cut, chopped and cut as the sun climbed, and soon he was so warm that he had to take off his

jacket. His mouth was dry, and his face was wet with sweat. 'My poor old father!' he thought. 'If only he was as warm as I!' And with that he began to chop even faster, thinking of the extra money he must earn to buy the saké to warm the old man's bones. Then suddenly Taro stopped chopping. What was that sound he heard? Could it be, could it possibly be rushing water? Taro could not remember ever seeing or hearing a rushing stream in that part of the forest. He was thirsty. The axe dropped out of his hands and he ran in the direction of the sound. 6. 7. Taro saw a beautiful little waterfall hidden behind a rock. Kneeling at a place where the water flowed quietly, he cupped a little in his hands and put it to his lips. Was it water? Or was it saké? He tasted it again and again, and always it was the delicious saké instead of cold water. Taro quickly filled the pitcher he had with him and hurried home. The old man was delighted with the saké. After usually made of mud 2019-202032 8. 9. 10. HONEYSUCKLE only one swallow of the liquid he stopped shivering and did a little dance in the middle of the floor. That afternoon, a neighbour stopped by for a visit. Taro's father politely offered her a cup of the saké. The lady drank it greedily, and thanked the old man. Then Taro told her the story of the magic waterfall. Thanking them for the delicious drink, she left in a hurry. By nightfall she had spread the story throughout the whole village. That evening there was a long procession of visitors to the woodcutter's house. Each man heard the story of the waterfall, and took a sip of the saké. In less than an hour the pitcher was empty. greedily: as if desiring more and more Next morning, Taro started for work even earlier than the morning before. He carried with him the largest pitcher he owned, for he intended first of all to go to the waterfall. When he reached it, he found to his great surprise all his neighbours there. They were carrying pitchers, jars, buckets — anything they could find to hold the magic saké. Then one villager knelt and held his mouth under the waterfall to drink. He drank again and again, and then shouted angrily, "Water! Nothing but water!" Others also tried, but there was no saké, only cold water.. 12. "We have been tricked!" shouted the villagers. "Where is Taro? Let us drown him in this waterfall." But Taro had been wise enough to slip behind a rock when he saw how things were going. He was nowhere to be found. tricked: deceived Muttering their anger and disappointment, the villagers left the place one by one. Taro came out from his hiding place. Was it true, he wondered? Was the saké a dream? Once more he caught a little liquid in his hand and put it to his lips. It was the same fine saké. To the thoughtful son, the magic waterfall gave the delicious saké. To everyone else, it gave only cold water.3. WORKING WITH THE TEXT HONEYSUCKLE The story of Taro and his magic waterfall reached the Emperor of Japan. He sent for the young woodcutter, and rewarded him with twenty pieces of gold for having been so good and kind. Then he named the most beautiful fountain in the city after Taro. This, said the Emperor, was to encourage all children to honour and obey their parents.Part I MANY VOICES RADHA 69 6 My favourite activity is climbing trees. Just outside our house, there is a mango tree which I love to go up. Its branches spread out, so it is simple to climb up the tree, and I can sit comfortably in the fork of two branches. My mother tells me it is not sensible for girls to climb trees, but one afternoon she climbed up too, and both of us sat there talking and eating raw mangoes. When I am high up in the tree, I feel like I can rule the whole world.When I grow up, I want to become a seed collector. We have cotton fields in our village and every year, my father spends a lot of money on buying new seeds to grow our cotton plants. My grandfather told me that many years ago, he could collect the seeds from his own plants which could be sown to grow new plants during the next year. But today that doesn't work so we have to spend money to buy new seeds every

single year. I want to find out why that is so. I want to learn how to preserve seeds so that we can use them again and not spend money every year. HONEYSUCKLE NASIR ROHIT If I had a huge amount of money I would travel and travel. I want to see the mountains of New Zealand because they looked beautiful in a magazine picture. I wish I could sail down the Amazon river in South America on a raft. I want to live on the beaches of Lakshadweep and dive down to see coral. I suppose I should go to the Konark temple in Orissa or the old city in Beijing in China and the Pyramids in Egypt too, but what I actually enjoy is seeing nature more than old buildings.

SERBJIT 71 What makes me very angry is when people don't believe me when I am telling the truth. For example, if I tell my teacher that I couldn't do my homework because Ravi borrowed my book and forgot to return it. Or I tell my parents that it wasn't me but my little brother who started the fight. Or if I tell my teacher that I really did study for the test even if I have got bad marks. They all look at me as if they think I am telling lies. The look on their faces really angers me. Sometimes I have to look down at my shoes and count to ten so that I do not show that I am angry.

DOLMA When I grow up, I am going to be the Prime Minister of India. People always laugh when I say that, but I am sure that I will do it. Everyone in my class asks me what to do when they have a problem, and my teacher always trusts me when something needs to be done in school. I want to make things better for everyone. I want us to have good hospitals and roads and schools. I want to make sure that there are many good scientists in India who will invent cures for diseases and send a spaceship to Mars.

HONEYSUCKLE PETER My favourite day is the second Sunday of every month. On this day our whole family always goes to the cinema hall to see a film. My father gets the tickets in advance and all of us —my grandmother, my parents, my two brothers and I —take the bus there. In the interval my father buys us peanuts and I love to sit in the darkness of the hall eating and watching the film. Afterwards we always stop to eat ice cream. Everyone is in a good mood and we all feel very lucky that we are such a happy family.

1. **THOUGH** the house and grounds belonged to my grandparents, the magnificent old banyan tree was mine — chiefly because Grandfather, at sixty-five, could no longer climb it. 2. Its spreading branches, which hung to the ground and took root again, forming a number of twisting passages, gave me endless pleasure. Among them were squirrels and snails and butterflies. The tree was older than the house, older than Grandfather, as old as Dehra Dun itself. I could hide myself in its branches, behind thick green leaves, and spy on the world below.

3. **spy**: watch secretly My first friend was a small grey squirrel. Arching his back and sniffing into the air, he seemed at first to resent my invasion of his privacy. But when he found that I did not arm myself with catapult or air gun, he became friendly, and when I started bringing him pieces of cake and biscuit he grew quite bold and was soon taking morsels from hand. Before long, he was delving into my pockets and helping himself to whatever he could find. He was a very young squirrel, and his friends and relatives probably thought him foolish and headstrong for trusting a human. In the spring, when the banyan tree was full of small red figs, birds of all kinds would flock into its branches: the red-bottomed bulbul, cheerful and greedy; parrots, myna and crows squabbling with one another. During the fig season, the banyan tree was the noisiest place in the garden. Halfway up the tree I had built a crude platform where I would spend the afternoons when it was not too hot. I could read there propping myself up against the tree with a cushion from the living room. Treasure Island, Huckleberry Finn and The Story of Dr Dolittle were some of the books that made up my banyan tree library.

6. When I did not feel like reading, I could look down through the leaves at the world below. And on one particular afternoon I had a

grandstand view of that classic of the Indian wilds, a fight between a mongoose and a cobra.

Part II 7. The warm breezes of approaching summer had sent everyone, including the gardener, into the house. I was feeling drowsy myself, wondering if I should go to the pond and have a swim with Ramu and the buffaloes, when I saw a huge black cobra gliding out of a clump of cactus. At the same time a mongoose emerged from the bushes and went straight for the cobra.

8. 127 grandstand view: a clear view from the best position (a grandstand is a large covered space with rows of seats for people to watch sports) gliding: moving smoothly clump: group (of bushes or trees) emerged: came out In a clearing beneath the banyan tree, in bright sunshine, they came face to face. The cobra knew only too well that the grey mongoose, three feet long, was a superb fighter, clever and aggressive. But the cobra, too, was a skilful and experienced fighter. He could move swiftly and strike with the speed of light; and the sacs behind his long sharp fangs were full of deadly poison. It was to be a battle of champions.. 10. HONEYSUCKLE Hissing defiance, his forked tongue darting in and out, the cobra raised three of his six feet off the ground, and spread his broad, spectacled hood. The mongoose bushed his tail. The long hair on his spine stood up. Though the combatants were unaware of my presence in the tree, they were soon made aware of the arrival of two other spectators. One was a myna, the other a jungle crow. They had seen these preparations for battle, and had settled on the cactus to watch the outcome. Had they been content only to watch, all would have been well with both of them.. 12. 13. The cobra stood on the defensive, swaying slowly from side to side, trying to mesmerise the mongoose into making a false move. But the mongoose knew the power of his opponent's glassy, unwinking eyes, and refused to meet them. Instead he fixed his gaze at a point just below the cobra's hood, and opened the attack. Moving forward quickly until he was just within the cobra's reach, the mongoose made a pretended move to one side. Immediately the cobra struck. His great hood came down so swiftly that I thought nothing could save the mongoose. But the little fellow jumped neatly to one side, and darted in as swiftly as the cobra, biting the snake on the back and darting away again out of reach. 129 mesmerise: here, magically persuade a false move: an unwise action 14. At the same moment that the cobra struck, the crow and the myna hurled themselves at him, only to collide heavily in mid-air. Shrieking insults at each other they returned to the cactus plant. A few drops of blood glistened on the cobra's back. The cobra struck and missed. Again the mongoose sprang aside, jumped in and bit. Again the birds dived at the snake, bumped into each other instead, and returned shrieking to the safety of the cactus.. 16. HONEYSUCKLE The third round followed the same course as the first but with one dramatic difference. The crow and the myna, still determined to take part in the proceedings, dived at the cobra; but this time they missed each other as well as their mark. The myna flew on and reached its perch, but the crow tried to pull up in mid-air and turn back. In the second that it took the bird to do this the cobra whipped his head back and struck with great force, his snout thudding against the crow's body. I saw the bird flung nearly twenty feet across the garden. It fluttered about for a while, then lay still. The myna remained on the cactus plant, and when THE BANYAN TREE the snake and the mongoose returned to the fight, very wisely decided not to interfere again! The cobra was weakening, and the mongoose, walking fearlessly up to it, raised himself on his short legs and with a lightning snap had the big snake by the snout. The cobra writhed and lashed about in a frightening manner, and even coiled itself about the mongoose, but to no avail. The little fellow hung grimly on, until the snake had ceased to struggle. He then smelt along its quivering length, gripped it round the hood, and dragged it into

the bushes. 17. The myna dropped cautiously to the ground, hopped about, peered into the bushes from a safe distance, and then, with a shrill cry of congratulation, flew away¹¹² Before you read Can you name some desert areas in India and the world? Who do you think lives in such areas? Desert Animals HONEYSUCKLE 9 1. DESERTS are the driest places on earth and sometimes go for months, or even years, without rain. But even the desert animals cannot survive without water, or for long periods in the scorching sun, so they have had to find different ways of coping with the harsh conditions. For example, gerbils spend the hottest part of the day in cool underground burrows. And strange insects called darkling beetles are experts at catching drops of moisture on their legs, then lifting them into the air until the drops trickle down into their mouths. Not all deserts are endless seas of rolling sand dunes. Some are rocky or pebbly and dotted with small bushes while others are sprinkled with colourful flowers during the spring. 2. scorching: very hot gerbils: mouse-like desert rodents with long hind legs dunes: heaps of sand formed by the wind pebbly: stony There are more than 2300 different kinds of snakes around the world, ranging from just fifteen centimetres long to more than eleven metres. Most snakes are quite harmless — but there are a few that are so poisonous they can kill a human being with just one bite. Most snakes lay eggs, but there are many which give birth to their young. In the dry, rocky deserts of America lives a rather evil-looking snake with a very bad reputation. Its frightening rattle can be heard as far as thirty metres away, and it can strike with lightning speed. ¹¹³ 3. But the rattlesnake, or ‘rattler’ as it is sometimes called, prefers to avoid people if it possibly can. It holds its tail upright and rattles the end whenever it is disturbed, in the hope that the intruder will go away. However, if its warnings are ignored—and it feels threatened—it will coil ready to bite. But the rattler itself cannot hear the noise its own tail makes. Like most snakes, it ‘hears’ things through vibrations in the ground. If a person walks nearby the snake can feel the movement. But if the same person were to shout, it would not hear a thing. Rattlesnakes are very common and widespread animals, living right across the American continent from Canada to Argentina. They feed on a variety of prey, including mice, voles, rats, chipmunks and many other small animals. Rattlesnakes kill their prey with venom. Like all snakes, they swallow the unfortunate animals whole. Few snakes have to eat more than once a week and some, such as the larger pythons, can survive for a year or more without eating. Mongooses like to hunt together, but they always keep a lookout for dangerous predators nearby. Poking their noses into holes, overturning rocks with their paws and scratching the ground with their sharp claws, banded mongooses are very amusing animals to watch. A common sight in many parts of Africa, they travel in groups of about twenty to forage for beetles, millipedes and other small creatures. 5. predator: an animal naturally preying on others. amusing: interesting; enjoyable. forage: search for food. They like to hunt together, keeping in touch whenever they go out of sight behind rocks or bushes by twittering and calling. Always on the lookout for danger — hawks, eagles and large snakes — they warn one another with a special alarm call if they spot anything suspicious DESERT ANIMALS 6. 7. 8. Mongooses are famous for being able to kill snakes without getting hurt themselves. Their reactions are so fast that they can dodge each time the snake strikes. They continually make a nuisance of themselves until, after a while, when the snake gets tired, they quickly dive in for the kill. All the female mongooses have their kitten at about the same time. They are raised by the whole group in a den made inside an old termite mound or hollow log. When most of the adults are out looking for food, one or two males stay behind to stand guard until the others return for the

night. 115 dodge: move quickly to avoid its enemy Another animal which lives in the desert is the camel. Camels were first domesticated by people many thousands of years ago. In the wild, camels usually live in small groups of up to thirty animals. Camels have long, shaggy winter coats to keep warm and shorter, tidier coats in the summer to keep cool. A thirsty camel can drink as much as thirty gallons of water — that's about five hundred full glasses — in just ten minutes. Normally, however, it gets all the moisture it needs from desert plants and can survive for up to ten months without drinking any water at all.⁹

HONEYSUCKLE There are two different kinds of camel. One, known as the Dromedary, has only a single hump; the other is called a Bactrian camel and has two humps. The humps help the animal to survive in the desert, by acting as storage containers. But they don't store water — as many people wrongly believe — they are full of fat. This fat nourishes the camels when food is scarce. If they have nothing to eat for several days, their humps shrink as the fat is used up. There are many other ways in which camels are adapted to desert life. Their mouths are so tough that even the sharp thorn cannot pierce through

THE presidents of the New York Central and the New York, New Haven and Hartford railroads will swear on a stack of timetables that there are only two. But I say there are three, because I've been on the third level of the Grand Central Station. Yes, I've taken the obvious step: I talked to a psychiatrist friend of mine, among others. I told him about the third level at Grand Central Station, and he said it was a wakingdream wish fulfillment. He said I was unhappy. That made my wife kind of mad, but he explained that he meant the modern world is full of insecurity, fear, war, worry and all the rest of it, and that I just want to escape. Well, who doesn't? Everybody I know wants to escape, but they don't wander down into any third level at Grand Central Station. But that's the reason, he said, and my friends all agreed. Everything points to it, they claimed. My stamp collecting, for example; that's a 'temporary refuge from reality.' Well, maybe, but my grandfather didn't need any refuge from reality; things were pretty nice and peaceful in his day, from all I hear, and he started my collection. It's a nice collection too, blocks of four of practically every U.S. issue, first-day covers, and so on. President Roosevelt collected stamps too, you know. Anyway, here's what happened at Grand Central. One night last summer I worked late at the office. I was in a hurry to get uptown to my apartment so I decided to take the subway from Grand Central because it's faster than the bus. Now, I don't know why this should have happened to me. I'm just an ordinary guy named Charley, thirty-one years old, and I was wearing a tan gabardine suit and a straw hat with a fancy band; I passed a dozen men who looked just like me. And I wasn't trying to escape from anything; I just wanted to get home to Louisa, my wife. I turned into Grand Central from Vanderbilt Avenue, and went down the steps to the first level, where you take trains like the Twentieth Century. Then I walked down another flight to the second level, where the suburban trains leave from, ducked into an arched doorway heading for the subway — and got lost. That's easy to do. I've been in and out of Grand Central hundreds of times, but I'm always bumping into new doorways and stairs and corridors. Once I got into a tunnel about a mile long and came out in the lobby of the Roosevelt Hotel. Another time I came up in an office building on Forty-sixth Street, three blocks away. Sometimes I think Grand Central is growing like a tree, pushing out new corridors and staircases like roots There's probably a long tunnel that nobody knows about feeling its way under the city right now, on its way to Times Square, and maybe another to Central Park. And maybe — because for so many people through the years Grand Central has been an exit, a way of escape — maybe that's how the tunnel I got into... But I never told my psychiatrist friend

about that idea. The corridor I was in began angling left and slanting downward and I thought that was wrong, but I kept on walking. All I could hear was the empty sound of my own footsteps and I didn't pass a soul. Then I heard that sort of hollow roar ahead that means open space and people talking. The tunnel turned sharp left; I went down a short flight of stairs and came out on the third level at Grand Central Station. For just a moment I thought I was back on the second level, but I saw the room was smaller, there were fewer ticket windows and train gates, and the information booth in the centre was wood and old-looking. And the man in the booth wore a green eyeshade and long black sleeve protectors. The lights were dim and sort of flickering. Then I saw why; they were open-flame gaslights. There were brass spittoons on the floor, and across the station a glint of light caught my eye; a man was pulling a gold watch from his vest pocket. He snapped open the cover, glanced at his watch and frowned. He wore a derby hat, a black four-button suit with tiny lapels, and he had a big, black, handlebar mustache. Then I looked around and saw that everyone in the station was dressed like eighteen-ninety-something; I never saw so many beards, sideburns and fancy mustaches in my life. A woman walked in through the train gate; she wore a dress with leg-of-mutton sleeves and skirts to the top of her high-buttoned shoes. Back of her, out on the tracks, I caught a glimpse of a locomotive, a very small Currier & Ives locomotive with a funnel-shaped stack. And then I knew. To make sure, I walked over to a newsboy and glanced at the stack of papers at his feet. It was *The World*; and *The World* hasn't been published for years. The lead story said something about President Cleveland. I've found that front page since, in the Public Library files, and it was printed June 11, 1894. I turned toward the ticket windows knowing that here — on the third level at Grand Central — I could buy tickets that would take Louisa and me anywhere in the United States we wanted to go. In the year 1894. And I wanted two tickets to Galesburg, Illinois. Have you ever been there? It's a wonderful town still, with big old frame houses, huge lawns, and tremendous trees whose branches meet overhead and roof the streets. And in 1894, summer evenings were twice as long, and people sat out on their lawns, the men smoking cigars and talking quietly, the women waving palm-leaf fans, with the fire-flies all around, in a peaceful world. To be back there with the First World War still twenty years off, and World War II over forty years in the future... I wanted two tickets for that. The clerk figured the fare — he glanced at my fancy hatband, but he figured the fare — and I had enough for two coach tickets, one way. But when I counted out the money and looked up, the clerk was staring at me. He nodded at the bills. "That ain't money, mister," he said, "and if you're trying to skin me, you won't get very far," and he glanced at the cash drawer beside him. Of course the money was old-style bills, half again as big as the money we use nowadays, and different-looking. I turned away and got out fast. There's nothing nice about jail, even in 1894. And that was that. I left the same way I came, I suppose. Next day, during lunch hour, I drew three hundred dollars out of the bank, nearly all we had, and bought old-style currency (that really worried my psychiatrist friend). You can buy old money at almost any coin dealer's, but you have to pay a premium. My three hundred dollars bought less than two hundred in old-style bills, but I didn't care; eggs were thirteen cents a dozen in 1894. But I've never again found the corridor that leads to the third level at Grand Central Station, although I've tried often enough. Louisa was pretty worried when I told her all this, and didn't want me to look for the third level any more, and after a while I stopped; I went back to my stamps. But now we're both looking, every weekend, because now we have proof that the third level is still there. My friend Sam Weiner disappeared! Nobody knew

where, but I sort of suspected because Sam's a city boy, and I used to tell him about Galesburg — I went to school there — and he always said he liked the sound of the place. And that's where he is, all right. In 1894. Because one night, fussing with my stamp collection, I found — Well, do you know what a first-day cover is? When a new stamp is issued, stamp collectors buy some and use them to mail envelopes to themselves on the very first day of sale; and the postmark proves the date. The envelope is called a first-day cover. They're never opened; you just put blank paper in the envelope. That night, among my oldest first-day covers, I found one that shouldn't have been there. But there it was. It was there because someone had mailed it to my grandfather at his home in Galesburg; that's what the address on the envelope said. And it had been there since July 18, 1894 — the postmark showed that — yet I didn't remember it at all. The stamp was a six-cent, dull brown, with a picture of President Garfield. Naturally, when the envelope came to Granddad in the mail, it went right into his collection and stayed there — till I took it out and opened it. The paper inside wasn't blank. It read: The note is signed Sam. At the stamp and coin store I go to, I found out that Sam bought eight hundred dollars' worth of old-style currency. That ought to set him up in a nice little hay, feed and grain business; he always said that's what he really wished he could do, and he certainly can't go back to his old business. Not in Galesburg, Illinois, in 1894. His old business? Why, Sam was my psychiatrist.